

BABUS' FLIGHTS OF FANCY

An INDIA TODAY investigation shows that despite calls for cost cutting, bureaucratic jaunts continue to bleed the exchequer

■ By Shyamlal Yadav

When Prime Minister Manmohan Singh recently wrote to his cabinet ministers, asking them to curtail their expenses on air travel and undertake foreign trips only when deemed "absolutely necessary", it was widely dismissed as an exercise in futility. After all, such steps in the past have not exactly produced the desired results. Indeed, a look at the volume of the babu traffic to overseas destinations suggests that the prime minister's lament amounts to howling after the horses have bolted the stable.

Following an investigation on frequent fliers in the UPA Government in February this year, INDIA TODAY filed separate Right to Information (RTI) applications to every Union ministry except the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on February 28 this year, seeking details of foreign visits made by officials of the rank of director and above. INDIA TODAY has received the information in 1,297 pages. The details of trips related to trainings of over one month have been excluded. The information gathered is a result of over 80 applications, clarifications, appeals and reminders. Despite these efforts, the ministries of Railways, Earth Sciences and the Department of Personnel and

Training are yet to give a final reply. Also, the designations and postings of a few officials may not be the latest as they may have been transferred or would have retired by now.

The information throws light on the fact that 1,576 officials of the rank of director and above have travelled more than 5.65 crore km and stayed 24,458 days abroad over the past 40 months (from January 1, 2005 to April 30, 2008). While details about the total expenses incurred were not made available, information received from 45 of the 50 Central ministries (including two departments: atomic energy and space) shows that officials from these ministries spent more than Rs 56.38 crore on globetrotting. In a few cases, costs include expenses incurred on delegates or companions but disaggregated figures were not provided.

Topping the list of frequent fliers is the Ministry of Commerce whose 101 officials have travelled more than 1.12 crore km, covering 5,751 days abroad and incurring a cost of Rs 8.99 crore. This mileage clocked by directors, joint secretaries (JS), additional secretaries (AS) and secretaries happens to be more than the one clocked by ministers from all ministries put together (1.02 crore km) during a period of three-and-a-half years. This may have been necessary to en-

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